

Case Study One

My Primary School is at Arbeia Roman Fort, South Shields

At the Arbeia Roman Fort opposite their school, a class of year five children experienced familiar subjects in a stimulating new environment. By the end of the three-month project, they were able to act as confident and knowledgeable tour guides for parents and visitors.

The whole school is now planning to use this unique heritage site much more. And the museum now plans to further develop its relationships with local schools and reach out to local families who may never have visited.

Key facts:

Hadrian Primary School

The school's location is one of geographical, cultural and historical significance, close to the River Tyne, the magnificent coastline, the recently restored South Marine Park and Arbeia, the Roman Fort. Hadrian Primary School prides itself on providing a warm and welcoming beginning to the children's journey of lifelong learning.

Arbeia Roman Fort

Built in AD 150 the Arbeia Roman Fort is a UNESCO world heritage site that offers a fascinating insight into life in Roman Britain. The fort once guarded the main sea route to Hadrian's Wall and was a key garrison and military supply base to other forts along the wall. Visitors can explore the excavated remains of the original fort and full-scale reconstructions of buildings including the West Gates and Commanding Officer's house and a soldier's barrack.

Dates of project:

4 January 2016 – 23 March 2016

Number of pupils and age of pupils involved:

29 year five pupils (nine and ten year olds)

School Team:

Stephanie Christie, Class Teacher
Scott Brown, Head Teacher

Museum Team:

Arbeia Roman Fort & Museum
Leslie Palanker-Jermyn, Assistant Learning Officer
Geoff Woodward, Museum Manager
Clare Smith, Learning Programmes Manager, Tyne & Wear Archives & Museums
Virginia Wilkinson, Learning Officer, North and South Tyneside

“For teaching across a broad curriculum, we've definitely discovered lots of new ways to utilise the space.”

Leslie Palanker-Jermyn, Arbeia

What happened during the project?

Arbeia's natural link with history informed much of the planning by class teacher Stephanie Christie. But she soon discovered she could cover more subjects than anticipated, including geography, maths and literacy. Writing was an important part of their activities: the children prepared their own log books of activities and were keen to tell the whole school and their parents about their experiences, using Twitter to post updates.

Complementing these sessions, workshops run by museum staff offered fascinating insights into life at the Roman Fort. One highlight was a time quest activity where the children became archaeologists and dug up some Roman artefacts which they then recorded in diary entries.

The children spent more time outside than usual, exploring the extensive archaeological remains. This opportunity encouraged their teacher to be creative with subjects such as maths, sending the children on an angle hunt with protractors and to look for Roman numerals.

“The creativity in the writing was phenomenal.”

Stephanie Christie, class teacher

Which activities were particularly memorable?

Slavery workshop – From baking bread and concocting herbal remedies to bed making and washing dirty nappies, the children became slaves for the day, working under the watchful eye of the commanding officer's wife, played by learning officer Leslie Palanker-Jermyn.

Guided tour - Drawing on what they had learnt during the project the children were able to interpret the heritage of Arbeia and act as tour guides for parents and visitors around the site.

“There is a change in their maturity, in how they approach the space and the building.”

Leslie Palanker-Jermyn, Arbeia

Benefits of the project:

Arbeia Roman Fort

- Hadrian Primary is a useful model for building strong relationships with schools
- Discover of new ideas on how to use the site for the whole curriculum
- Gave opportunity to work through logistical challenges and gave an insight into how to fully exploit museum space to accommodate school groups.

Hadrian's Primary School

- Introduced staff to a valuable and easily accessible teaching asset, and the potential use of the site for staff training and meetings.

- Developed a more creative and flexible approach to teaching.

"I think it's opened their eyes to actually what we've got on our doorstep, which is a fantastic site that you can use for learning with the children."

Stephanie Christie, class teacher

Children

- Increased enthusiasm for learning led them to generate their own ideas for teaching sessions
- Writing about their Arbeia activities and using new vocabulary have improved literacy skills
- A desire to share their experience and new knowledge with other children and their families.

"They've got an even deeper interest in their learning than they had before."

Stephanie Christie, Class Teacher

What were the main challenges?

Incorporating the whole curriculum – It was difficult to teach subjects such as PE and ICT at the site.

Logistics – Arbeia had to make adaptations to the site, such as changing the acoustics in one of the teaching spaces, to make the most of the setting.

Co-ordinating activities – It was sometimes difficult to plan and use time to the full due to the children having to fit in with school routines, such as registration, and attending some break times and assemblies.